

GovCon BD Upskilling Program

Buyer Intelligence Basics

Module 1.2 | Domain D1 (23%)

DURATION

2-3 hours

FORMAT

Live Instructor-Led

GovConGiants

30-Day Foundation Program

Module 1.2: Buyer Intelligence Basics

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, learners will be able to:

1. **Navigate** SAM.gov Contract Data to research historical contract awards and agency spending
2. **Identify** key buyers within target agencies using spending data
3. **Analyze** spending patterns by NAICS code and product/service category
4. **Research** incumbent contractors and their contract history
5. **Document** agency intelligence in a structured research report

Required Reading/Viewing

Official Government Resources (Free)

1. **SAM.gov Contract Data** - Contract Award Search
 - URL: <https://sam.gov/content/contract-data>
 - Focus: Searching federal contract awards and historical data
 - Note: Requires free SAM.gov account to access
2. **SAM.gov Contract Data Help**
 - URL: <https://sam.gov/help/contract-data>
 - Focus: Navigation and search functions
3. **USAspending.gov** - “Agency Profiles”
 - URL: <https://www.usaspending.gov>
 - Focus: Agency-level spending analysis (no account required)

Action Plan Journal References

- **Identify Top Ten Customers:** page 35
- **Forecast List for Agencies:** page 36
- **Customer Management List:** pages 38-47
- **Where to Find POC Information:** pages 53-56

Lesson Content

1. Why Buyer Intelligence Matters

Buyer intelligence is the foundation of effective business development. Understanding who buys what, from whom, and for how much allows you to:

- **Target the right opportunities** - Focus on agencies that actually buy what you sell
- **Position competitively** - Know who you're competing against
- **Time your outreach** - Understand when contracts are expiring
- **Build relationships** - Identify the right contacts

Your Role

Even if you're not in BD, recognizing buyer patterns helps you support growth efforts and spot opportunities in your day-to-day work.

2. Introduction to SAM.gov Contract Data

SAM.gov Contract Data is now the official source for federal contract award information. (Note: This functionality was previously on FPDS.gov, which was retired in February 2026.)

What SAM.gov Contract Data Contains:

- Contract award details (who won, how much, when)
- Contracting agency and office
- NAICS codes and PSC codes
- Contract type (FFP, T&M, IDIQ, etc.)
- Small business designations
- Period of performance

What It Does NOT Contain:

- Future opportunities (use SAM.gov Contract Opportunities for that)
- Classified contracts
- Grants or cooperative agreements

3. Navigating SAM.gov Contract Data

Accessing Contract Data:

1. Go to <https://sam.gov>
2. Create a free account (required to search contract data)
3. Click "Contract Data" in the main navigation

4. Select “Contract Award Search” to find awards

Key Search Fields:

Vendor Name	Find contracts awarded to a specific company	“Booz Allen”
Contracting Agency	Filter by agency	“Department of Veterans Affairs”
NAICS Code	Filter by industry classification	“541512”
PSC Code	Filter by product/service category	“D302”
Date Range	Limit to specific fiscal years	FY2024-FY2025
Award Amount	Filter by contract size	“\$1M to \$10M”

Tip

If you don’t have a SAM.gov account yet, USAspending.gov provides similar data without requiring an account, though SAM.gov offers more granular search capabilities.

4. Understanding NAICS and PSC Codes

NAICS Codes (North American Industry Classification System):

- 6-digit codes classifying businesses by industry
- Used for size standard determination
- Example: 541512 = Computer Systems Design Services

PSC Codes (Product Service Codes):

- 4-character codes describing what the government bought
- More specific than NAICS
- Example: D302 = IT and Telecom - Systems Development

Why Both Matter:

- NAICS tells you what industry the contractor is in
- PSC tells you what specific service/product was purchased
- Use both to find relevant opportunities

5. Researching Agency Spending Patterns

Key Questions to Answer:

1. How much does this agency spend?

- Total contract dollars annually
- Trend over past 3-5 years

2. What do they buy?

- Top PSC codes
- Top NAICS codes

3. Who do they buy from?

- Top contractors by award value
- Small business vs. large business split

4. How do they buy?

- Contract vehicles used (GSA, agency IDIQ, standalone)
- Competition type (full & open, set-aside, sole source)

5. When do contracts expire?

- Recompete opportunities
- Option year timing

6. Incumbent Research**Why Research Incumbents:**

- Understand current performance expectations
- Identify potential teaming partners
- Assess competitive landscape
- Find recompetete opportunities

What to Look For:

Contract value	SAM.gov Contract Data	Size of opportunity
Period of performance	SAM.gov Contract Data	When it expires
Contract type	SAM.gov Contract Data	Risk profile
Past modifications	SAM.gov Contract Data	Scope changes, issues
Other agency work	SAM.gov Contract Data	Incumbent's breadth
Company size	DSBS, SAM.gov	Teaming considerations

7. Using USAspending for Agency Analysis

USAspending.gov provides a more user-friendly view of spending data.

Key Features:

1. **Agency Profiles:** Overview of each agency's spending
2. **Recipient Profiles:** See all awards to a specific contractor
3. **Spending Explorer:** Drill down by category, location, time
4. **Award Search:** Find specific contracts

When to Use Each Tool:

Agency overview	USAspending
Specific contract details	SAM.gov Contract Data
Contractor research	Both
Historical trends	USAspending
Detailed award data	SAM.gov Contract Data

AI Accelerator: Using AI for Buyer Intelligence

AI tools can help you analyze SAM.gov contract data, research incumbents, and synthesize buyer intelligence faster.

Prompt 1: Analyze Contract Award Data

Use When: You've exported SAM.gov contract data and need help making sense of it.

I pulled the following contract award data from SAM.gov for [AGENCY NAME]:

[PASTE YOUR CONTRACT DATA - contractor names, award amounts, dates, NAICS codes]

Please analyze this data and tell me:

1. Who are the dominant contractors and what's their market share?
2. What patterns do you see in contract types (FFP vs T&M vs CPFF)?
3. Are there any contractors that appear to be growing or declining?
4. What's the average contract size and duration?
5. Any insights for a company trying to enter this market?

Prompt 2: Incumbent Contractor Profile

Use When: You need to research a specific competitor or incumbent.

I'm researching [COMPETITOR NAME], a federal contractor. Help me build an intel profile:

- 1. What should I look for in SAM.gov Contract Data to understand their portfolio?
- 2. What are typical strengths of established incumbents?
- 3. What vulnerabilities might a long-term incumbent have?
- 4. How can I find out about their subcontracting relationships?
- 5. What questions should I be asking about this competitor?

Note: I'll verify all specific data against official sources.

Prompt 3: NAICS/PSC Code Research

Use When: You need to understand which codes are relevant to your services.

Our company provides [DESCRIBE YOUR SERVICES].

- Help me identify:
- 1. The most relevant NAICS codes for our services
 - 2. The most relevant PSC codes we should be tracking
 - 3. Which codes typically have small business set-asides
 - 4. Any related codes we might be missing
 - 5. How to search SAM.gov Contract Data using these codes effectively

Pro Tips for AI-Assisted Buyer Intelligence

Export SAM.gov data and paste into AI for analysis	Ask AI for current contract values
Use AI to identify patterns in large datasets	Rely on AI for competitor revenue figures
Ask AI to help structure your research approach	Skip verification against official sources

Use AI to draft briefings from your research	Present AI analysis as verified intelligence
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Remember

AI helps you work faster, but SAM.gov Contract Data and USAspending are your authoritative sources. Always verify before sharing intelligence with your team.

Applied Exercise: Agency Research Report

Scenario: Your company is considering pursuing opportunities with a specific federal agency. Your manager asks you to research the agency's spending patterns and identify potential opportunities.

Part 1: Select Your Target Agency

Choose ONE agency from this list (or select one relevant to your company):

- Department of Veterans Affairs (VA)
- Department of Homeland Security (DHS)
- Department of Health and Human Services (HHS)
- General Services Administration (GSA)
- Department of Energy (DOE)

Part 2: Research Using SAM.gov Contract Data

1. Go to <https://sam.gov> and log in (free account required)
2. Navigate to Contract Data → Contract Award Search
3. Filter by your selected agency
4. Set date range to most recent 2 fiscal years
5. Document: Total spending, Top 5 contractors, Top 5 PSC/NAICS codes

Part 3: Research Using USAspending

1. Go to <https://www.usaspending.gov>
2. Navigate to your agency's profile
3. Document: Year-over-year trend, Small business %, Top contracting offices

Time: 45-60 minutes

Work Artifact: Agency Research Report

Quick Summary Section

Your Name: _____

Date: _____

Target Agency: _____

Key Findings

Total Annual Contract Spending	\$
Year-over-Year Change	%
Small Business Share	%
Top Contractor	
Top PSC Code	
Top NAICS Code	

Top 5 Contractors

1		\$	
2		\$	
3		\$	
4		\$	
5		\$	

Relevance Assessment

Does this agency buy what we sell?

Recommended Next Steps

I Knowledge Check (Self-Assessment)

Question 1 (Application)

You want to find all IT services contracts awarded by the VA in FY2025. Which SAM.gov Contract Data search fields would you use?

- A) Vendor Name and Award Amount
- B) **Contracting Agency, NAICS Code, and Date Range**
- C) PSC Code only
- D) Contract Type and Place of Performance

Correct Answer: B

Question 2 (Recall)

What is the difference between NAICS codes and PSC codes?

- A) NAICS codes are for products, PSC codes are for services
- B) **NAICS codes classify the contractor's industry, PSC codes describe what was purchased**
- C) NAICS codes are used by DoD only, PSC codes are government-wide
- D) There is no difference; they are interchangeable

Correct Answer: B

Question 3 (Scenario)

Your company wants to pursue a VA contract currently held by a competitor. Using SAM.gov Contract Data, you discover the contract expires in 6 months with no remaining options. What does this tell you?

- A) The contract will automatically renew
- B) **A recompetete opportunity is likely coming soon**
- C) The incumbent will definitely win again
- D) The VA no longer needs this service

Correct Answer: B

Question 4 (Application)

You're researching agency spending trends. Which tool provides the easiest view of year-over-year spending changes?

- A) SAM.gov Contract Data
- B) SAM.gov
- C) **USAspending.gov Agency Profiles**
- D) DSBS

Correct Answer: C

Manager Discussion Prompts

1. **Current Context:** "Which agencies are we currently targeting or working with? How do we track their spending patterns?"
2. **Application:** "Are there specific competitors we should be researching? How can I contribute to our competitive intelligence?"
3. **Career Development:** "What agency research skills would be most valuable for me to develop further?"

Completion Criteria

To complete this module:

- ☐ Read all required materials (approximately 30 minutes)
- ☐ Complete the lesson content review (30-45 minutes)
- ☐ Finish the Applied Exercise using SAM.gov Contract Data and USAspending
- ☐ Submit a completed Agency Research Report
- ☐ Review the Knowledge Check questions (self-assessment)
- ☐ Participate in manager discussion (or document self-reflection)

Estimated Total Time: 2-3 hours

Additional Resources

Free Tools for Deeper Research

SAM.gov Contract Data	sam.gov/content/contract-data	Detailed contract data
USAspending	usaspending.gov	Agency spending overview
DSBS	dsbs.sba.gov	Contractor research
SAM.gov Entity Search	sam.gov	Verify contractor status

Key Terms

SAM.gov Contract Data: The official federal contract award database (replaced FPDS.gov in Feb 2026)

NAICS Code: North American Industry Classification System - classifies businesses by industry

PSC Code: Product Service Code - describes what was purchased

Incumbent: Current contractor performing work on a contract

Recompete: Follow-on competition when a contract expires

Action Plan Journal Activities

After completing this module, use your **Action Plan Journal** to:

1. Begin your **Customer Management List** (pages 38-47) for your target agency
2. Start your **Forecast List** (page 36) based on contract expiration dates you found
3. Document POC information using the **POC Information for Agencies** template (pages 57-64)

Journal Reference

The Agency Research Report you completed connects directly to the Customer Management List in your Action Plan Journal. Transfer your findings to keep everything in one place.